

M.K. NARAYANAN | NATIONAL SECURITY ADVISER

The Great Procrastinator

His Highness Maharaja Bahadur Hari Singh and Mayankote Kelath Narayanan don't have much in common. But they seem to share a passion for the lethal art of procrastination. The Maharaja too had dithered to take a decision on aligning with one of the two sides. Six decades later, it is National Security Adviser (NSA) M.K. Narayanan's turn to be indecisive. As the NSA, he waited in limbo as Jammu and Kashmir burned. The first whiff of protest against the land transfer came when on June 12, the Hurriyat Conference came out with a statement against the decision. It took another 12 days for the protests to reach the streets. During the long warming-up period, Narayanan was busy with political diplomacy, ensuring support for the Manmohan Singh Government or chaperoning Indo-US nuclear deal. Nick-

named Normally Stationed Abroad, he chose to travel to the UK, Canada and Russia to enlist support for the N-deal through the crisis in Kashmir.

Narayanan sat on many initiatives of New Delhi aimed at connecting Kashmiris across the LOC. Narayanan, who took over as NSA in 2005, was more involved in duties like information collection for political bosses than his primary task. He took to political management with unequalled flair and was even accused by Panthers Party chief Bhim Singh of threatening him before the Assembly trust vote. Kashmir is the latest in Narayanan's list of goof-ups, which also includes a series of bomb blasts across major cities. The National Security Adviser's trademark stupor has neither helped him nor the country.

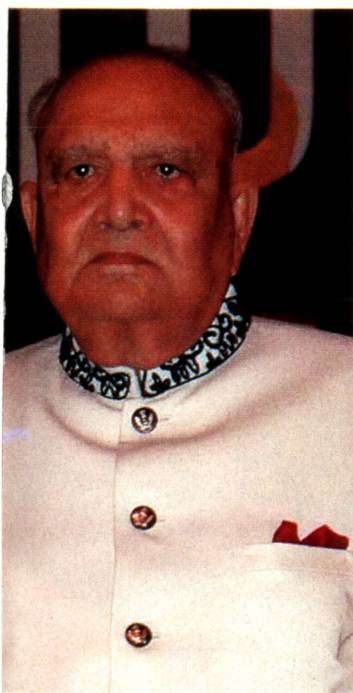
by Shafi Rahman

SIPRA DAS



"POLITICAL VACUUM IN PAKISTAN ALLOWS RADICAL OUTFITS TO DO WHAT THEY LIKE ON OUR SIDE OF THE BORDER TOO."

M.K. Narayanan, National Security Adviser



S.K. SINHA | FORMER GOVERNOR

The Revivalist

As someone who fought the Pakistani raiders in Kashmir in 1947-48, Lt-General (retd) S.K. Sinha took his gubernatorial stint in the state as an opportunity to leave behind a legacy as a builder of a religious institution—the Shri Amarnath Shrine Board. He allowed his role as chairman of the Board to override his constitutional position. After becoming governor in 2003, Sinha made implementation of the board's mandate his obsession, which not only put him at loggerheads with the then chief minister Mufti Mohammad Sayeed, but also made the predominantly Muslim Valley suspicious of his motives. Sinha's first decision to set up pre-fabricated shelters en route to the pilgrimage was turned down by Mufti. The chief minister and governor were not even on talking

terms. However, soon after Ghulam Nabi Azad took over the reins as chief minister in 2005, he wrote to the council of ministers for the transfer of the 100-acre land to the board.

Sinha pushed the case for three years till Azad got the cabinet to pass an order on the land transfer in June, three months ahead of the Assembly elections. But Sinha misjudged the strong reaction it would evoke in the Valley. He discounted that parties were in poll mode, separatists looking for a chance and PDP's talent in rank opportunism. His misplaced ambition to promote "Kashmiriyat" backfired in the Valley as the separatists charged that land transfer to the board was an attempt to "establish a Hindu enclave in Kashmir". The seasoned army man has been laid low by the guerrillas in the Valley.

by Ramesh Vinayak

"I REGRET WHAT SHOULD HAVE BEEN A DEBATE BETWEEN KASHMIRIS AND HARDLINERS TURNED INTO A DIVIDE."

S.K. Sinha, Former Governor